

Fostering collaboration

FOSS vendors help foster collaboration, which indirectly stimulates demand and confidence in consumers. "When there is a need for a particular solution, one FOSS partner in the ecosystem can possibly resolve one part of the problem, while another partner can contribute its core strength towards solving another part of the problem. For example, in the embedded domain, when we design a product, we look for partners with exposure and experience in high-end Linux GUI applications—those who can write applications on the Linux embedded systems we build. A proper ecosystem and interaction among the Indian FOSS companies would help Indian companies pitch in with more integrated solutions, and thereby, help India emerge as a desired FOSS destination," adds Maharajan Veerabahu, project manager, e-con Systems. Numerous efforts like conducting conferences, events and virtual platforms are helping bring about such collaboration between stakeholders.

Virtual platforms

Virtual forums help bring together potential collaborators. For example, online forums, like FOSSyellowpages.com, allow FOSS companies to interact with prospective clients and partners, and job sites like fossjobs.in help connect the talent pool with companies working on FOSS. "Both the portals are very good initiatives to not only make India a FOSS powerhouse, but also address the FOSS consumer's concern about the lack of an adequate ecosystem supporting FOSS," says Deepak Gupta, associate vice president, technology, GlobalLogic. "FOSSyellowpages.com comes in very handy for customers to find the right companies that build solutions on FOSS platforms. This is sure to bridge the huge gap in identifying partners

for development, and will encourage ISVs to pick FOSS platforms for their development. Along with that, dedicated FOSS job sites help find those with niche skill-sets and experience, which is critical for a company using FOSS," adds Gokul Muralidharan, open source specialist, Aspire Systems.

Events and conferences

Events and conferences provide a forum that brings members of an ecosystem together, to showcase its strength to consumers. It also helps project a unified and sharply focused message about FOSS or a particular FOSS project. Says Vishwas Mudagal, CEO, Castle Rock Research India, "One needs to constantly upgrade one's skills and knowledge to create world-class products, especially when the FOSS world is progressing every second. Events like the Ruby Conference India create tremendous awareness about FOSS among professionals and companies, giving the community an opportunity to learn about the latest advances in FOSS by interacting with experts in the field. We intend to host many such events in Bangalore and Kolkata in the coming months. A few of these events will be hosted entirely by Castle Rock, to push the FOSS community." There are an increasing number of FOSS events that are changing the perception of the FOSS community globally as well. "Events like FOSS.in, GNUUnify, and Freed help connect the community, and increase the level of participation. From a business perspective, LinuxAsia in its earlier and current incarnation, OSI (Open Source India) Days, has potential," says Mohan.

So, strengthening the links between consumers, facilitators and producers in the FOSS ecosystem will help build a buzz around open source, and drive India towards becoming a FOSS powerhouse. 

By: Vanisha Joseph

The author loves to experiment, and writing for *LINUX For You* is her latest experiment—so beware! Just a minute, she also happens to be a journalist during the day

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